FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
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New Audit: Controller Kenneth Mejia's Office Finds That Los Angeles Animal Services Is Too Under-Resourced to Both Provide Humane Care *and* Achieve Save Rate Goals

Controller's Audit Recommends Steps for LAAS To Align With Best Practices for Animal Welfare

Controller Continues To Recommend the Mayor and City Council Increase Funding for More Staff, Spay and Neuter, and LAAS as a Whole

LOS ANGELES – The Office of City Controller Kenneth Mejia today released a performance audit of the capacity of Los Angeles Animal Services (LAAS) to care for the volume of animals entering its shelters relative to current resources. The audit focuses primarily on shelter capacity, shelter resources, and the effectiveness of certain business management functions.

The audit covers fiscal years 2021-2025: July 1, 2020 - June 30, 2025.

The audit was conducted by the Controller's Office's civil service Audit Services Division. The Audit Services Division will also publish a subsequent highly technical and robust evaluation of animal care practices in conjunction with a veterinary consultant that specializes in animal shelter management.

Full audit: **bit.ly/laas-audit**

Key Findings

- **LAAS lacks the sufficient staff to provide humane or adequate care for shelter animals.** During our audit, we found that LAAS assigned 75 animal shelter care staff during the dayshift (this doesn't account for absences so the actual count may be lower than 75) when the minimum should be 90 staff based on kennel capacity. In addition, during times of peak overcrowding, there should have been at least 185 staff, 2.5 times more than the amount LAAS had assigned.
- **LAAS receives more animals than shelters can handle and its save rate goals may compromise animal welfare.** LAAS accepts animals that are surrendered by their owners, regardless of capacity concerns. The cities of Long Beach, San Jose, and Fresno, and San Diego County generally do not accept – or limit intake – of owner surrendered animals. During our audit scope period, we found that the daily average of the dog population was 35% over capacity and during extreme periods of overcrowding in 2023 and 2024, 100% over capacity. The capacity for dogs is 737. We also found that the daily average of the cat population was 131% over capacity and during extreme periods of overcrowding, 300% over capacity. The capacity for cats is 340. The City has paid $15.8 million in liability payments for LAAS cases related to dangerous conditions or professional negligence.
- **LAAS Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) are outdated, no longer reflect current operations, or are nonexistent for issues like unsanitary conditions.** The department has 162

SOPs covering shelter operations, medical services, finance, and administrative services. Most however have not been updated since approximately 2010. We also found that LAAS does not have a formal SOP for sanitation including protocols for removing organic matter and effectively cleaning kennels.

- **Dog licensing is low and enforcement is limited, resulting in less revenue for the City, and an inability to confirm that pet owners are vaccinating dogs to protect against rabies.** Between FY 2021 and FY 2025, owners failed to respond to 71,128 license renewal notifications for one-year licenses and 8,790 three-year licenses that were sent out by LAAS. Estimates indicate the City may be missing out on up to $14.1 million in license revenue, which could fund animal care and highlights the need for improved licensing enforcement. In addition, the Los Angeles Municipal Code requires that all veterinarians send in proof of rabies vaccine certificates to the department. However, only 26 veterinary offices (out of the 379 offices that are registered within the City) regularly submit vaccine certificates, or are planning to begin submitting the information to the City.
- **The Shelter Volunteer Program needs improvement as both LAAS staff and volunteers reported that tension between the two groups can create a difficult work environment for all involved.** While the vast majority of volunteers are positive contributors at animal shelters, both LAAS staff and volunteers reported that tension between the two groups can create a difficult work environment for all parties. Our Office interviewed 14 volunteers who were part of the top 30% of hours volunteered over the past three fiscal years. Overall, volunteers indicated satisfaction with their volunteer experience at City animal shelters, however, ranked working with LAAS staff lowest (2.9 out of 5) and working with other volunteers highest (4.8 out of 5). Volunteers' experiences with LAAS employees included having communication issues, including being ignored when asking for assistance and not being updated about new policies and procedures. Volunteers also generally felt that shelters were crowded, that the number of employees was insufficient to fully care for the animals, and expressed some concerns about unnecessary euthanasia determinations. We also found that the volunteer program does not have a system to ensure that volunteer discipline is being applied in a fair, consistent manner.

Key Recommendations

- Besides City Hall leaders appropriately funding LAAS, the department should create a comprehensive recruiting, hiring, and funding plan for animal care and submit this plan to the Mayor and City Council for consideration.
- When a shelter is at a capacity where it can no longer provide adequate, humane care to shelter animals, establish a policy limiting the intake of animals voluntarily surrendered by their owners.
- Conduct a review of existing SOPs with the goal of updating existing policies to accurately reflect LAAS' current operations and address potential gaps. This process should ensure alignment with industry best practices and involve consolidating or eliminating any policies that are obsolete, duplicative, or no longer necessary.
- Implement new enforcement procedures for City dog licensing requirements, which could include mechanisms implemented by peer jurisdictions such as automatic citations or fines for individuals who fail to respond to requests to license their pet.
- Identify veterinary service providers operating within the City who are not submitting rabies vaccination certificate information to LAAS, as mandated by the Los Angeles Municipal code, and inform them of relevant vaccine certificate reporting requirements.

- LAAS should take steps to understand volunteer concerns, solicit ideas and feedback, and foster improved working relationships between volunteers and LAAS employees.
- LAAS should develop a policy for volunteer discipline that includes fact finding requirements, penalty ranges, and factors for consideration when making discipline determinations when volunteers violate the Volunteer Rules and Guidelines as this will increase transparency around the process, create a shared understanding of rules and expectations, and help to ensure the department handles cases in a consistent and fair manner.

In addition to the recommendations in the audit, the Controller's Office continues to strongly support increasing funding for LAAS so the department can expand services including spay and neuter, animal enrichment, and owner support.

Controller Mejia said, "City Hall has failed the animals in our care. From constant budget and staffing cuts to an already under-resourced Animal Services department to the Mayor proposing to shut down three of our six animal shelters and completely eliminating animal food and canine enrichment, animal welfare is clearly not a priority in City Hall.

"Animals have been suffering in overcrowded, under-resourced City shelters. This is a persistent crisis the City must fix. Our Office conducted this audit in order to get an in-depth look at shelter policies and determine changes the City can make to improve animals' lives, both immediately and long-term.

"Our Office will keep advocating for our City's animals and we'll keep providing transparency on shelter conditions, policies, and data. By following our recommendations, LAAS and the City can vastly improve the lives of the thousands of animals that go through the shelter system every year."

Previous LA Animal Services Reports and Data Tools by Controller Mejia's Office
- *Transparency Report: LA Animal Services Shelter Operations and Animal Care*
- *LAAS Spay Neuter and Shelter Map*
- *LAAS Transparency Charts data dashboard*

Audits and Assessments by Controller Mejia's Office

Completed:
- *LAPD's Mental Evaluation Unit & SMART Co-response Model*
- *Housing Audit: Affordable Housing Oversight*
- *Housing Audit: TAHO*
- *Homelessness Audit: Pathways to Permanent Housing*
- *LAPD Military Equipment*
- *LAPD Helicopters*
- *Homelessness Audit: Interim Housing*

In progress:
- *CARE/CARE+*
- *Risk Management Practices to Reduce Harm and Liability Payouts*